Access request approval workflow and timelines

Article KB0010012 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: Access request | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, Microsoft Entra ID (Azure AD) and on-prem Active Directory, SharePoint Online, OneDrive, file shares accessed via PaperCut, HR systems and distribution lists managed in Entra ID

Summary

This article describes the access request approval workflow at Acme Global, including how users submit requests, manager approval steps, provisioning timelines, and how to verify granted access. It also provides a self-help procedure for users and a detailed process for service-desk agents to handle requests within SLA.

Symptoms

- "You don't have permission to access this folder" when opening a shared drive
- "Access denied" error in SharePoint or Teams when clicking a link
- Unable to open HR application - message: "Your account is not authorized"
- Distribution list email bounces with "User not a member of the list"
- Self-service password reset works but subsequent resource access fails

Common causes

- Request submitted without required manager approval
- Manager approval recorded but security group not yet provisioned (propagation delay)
- Incorrect target group or distribution list selected in the request form
- Request stuck in pending state due to missing temporary access pass or MFA requirement
- User's account not yet synchronized between on-prem AD and Entra ID causing group membership to not apply

Understanding the Access Request Approval Workflow

All access requests at Acme Global follow a two-step approval model: the requester submits a request via the self-service portal (or through the IT Help Teams channel) and specifies the resource, business justification, and required manager. The request is then routed to the designated manager for approval. Once the manager approves, the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team provisions the appropriate security group or distribution list, and the change propagates to the target systems. Propagation typically completes within 30 minutes for on-prem file shares and within an hour for cloud services such as SharePoint and HR applications.

Self-Help Procedure: Submit an Access Request

Users can initiate most access requests themselves using the IT self-service portal. The procedure below walks you through filling out the form, attaching any required documentation, and tracking the request until you receive confirmation.

1. Open a browser and go to the IT self-service portal at https://it.acme.example.
2. Sign in with your Acme corporate credentials (username@acme.example) and approve the MFA prompt.
3. From the homepage, select "Request Access" under the Identity & Access Management tile.
4. Choose the resource type: Shared Drive (file share), SharePoint Site, HR System, or Distribution List.
5. Enter the exact name or path of the resource (e.g., \\fileserver\FinanceShare or https://contoso.sharepoint.com/sites/Finance).
6. Provide a brief business justification (max 200 characters) and select your manager from the dropdown list.
7. If attaching a supporting document (e.g., project charter), click "Add Attachment" and upload the file.
8. Review the summary, then click "Submit Request". You will receive a ticket number via email and a notification in the Teams "IT Help" channel.
9. Monitor the request status in the portal under "My Requests". When the manager approves, the status changes to "Approved - Pending Provisioning".
10. After provisioning (usually within 30?minutes for file shares, up to 1?hour for cloud services), sign out of Windows/macOS and sign back in, or refresh your browser/Teams client to see the new access.

Timelines and Notifications

Once a request is submitted, the workflow moves through several predictable stages. Understanding these stages helps set expectations and know when to follow up.

1. **Stage 1 - Request Received** (0-5?minutes): An automated acknowledgment email is sent with the ticket number.
Stage 2 - Manager Approval (target <=?4?business hours for P2 requests, <=?8?hours for P3): The manager receives an email and a Teams notification; they must click "Approve" or "Deny". If no action is taken, the request auto-escalates to the manager's delegate after 2?hours.
Stage 3 - IAM Provisioning (<=?30?minutes for on-prem groups, <=?1?hour for cloud groups): Upon approval, the IAM team adds the user to the appropriate security group or distribution list. The change is written to Entra ID and, where applicable, to on-prem AD via Azure AD Connect.
Stage 4 - Propagation Confirmation (<=?30?minutes after provisioning): Systems such as file shares, SharePoint, and HR apps refresh group membership. Users receive a final email stating "Access granted" and are advised to sign out/in or refresh.
Total SLA: For most access requests (P2/P3) the combined timeline is <=?4?hours from submission to usable access, well within the published resolution targets.

Verifying That Access Has Been Granted

After you receive the "Access granted" notification, perform a quick validation to confirm that the resource is reachable and that you have the expected permissions.

1. For a file share: Open File Explorer, enter the UNC path (e.g., \\fileserver\FinanceShare) and verify you can view/create files.
For a SharePoint site: Navigate to the site URL in your browser; ensure the site loads and you can edit documents as per your role.
For an HR system: Launch the application via the Company Portal or direct URL; confirm you can log in and see the relevant modules.
For a distribution list: Send a test email to the list address and verify you receive it in your inbox (or ask a colleague to confirm receipt).
If any of these checks fail, wait 10?minutes and repeat; if the issue persists, proceed to the escalation steps below.

Service-Desk Agent Procedure: Processing Access Requests

Agents in the Identity & Access Management group (or the Service Desk L1 when acting as the first point of contact) should follow this procedure to ensure requests are handled correctly, within SLA, and with proper documentation.

1. 1. **Ticket Intake** - Verify the ticket originates from the self-service portal, Teams "IT Help" channel, or phone. Capture the ticket number, requester's name, employee ID, and requested resource.
2. **Validate Information** - Ensure the request includes:
   - Exact resource identifier (share path, site URL, system name, or distribution list alias).
   - Business justification.
   - Correct manager (as per the organizational chart in Workday).
   If any item is missing, add a comment requesting clarification and set the ticket to "Pending User Input".
3. **Check for Existing Access** - Using the Entra ID portal or PowerShell (Get-AzureADGroupMember -ObjectId <groupId>), confirm the user is not already a member of the target group. If they are, close the ticket with "Access Already Granted" and provide evidence.
4. **Manager Approval Verification** - Look for the approval entry in the ticket workflow (email approval, Teams approval, or approval recorded in the portal). If approval is missing, send a reminder to the manager and set a follow-up for 2?hours.
5. **Provision the Group** - Once approval is confirmed:
   - For on-prem security groups: Use Active Directory Users and Computers or the Azure AD Connect sync rule to add the user.
   - For cloud groups (SharePoint, HR, distribution lists): Use the Entra ID portal or the appropriate admin center to add the user to the group.
   Document the group name, object ID, and timestamp in the ticket.

6. **Communicate Propagation Timeline** - Inform the user that access will be available within 30?minutes (on-prem) or up to 1?hour (cloud). Advise them to sign out/in or refresh.
7. **Close the Ticket** - After the propagation window, request the user to confirm access (see verification steps). Upon confirmation, set the ticket status to "Resolved", add a closing note with the group added and confirmation time, and resolve according to the priority (typically P2 -> 8?h SLA, P3 -> 24?h).

When to escalate

If a request remains in "Pending Manager Approval" beyond 4?business hours (or 2?hours after the first reminder), escalate to the manager's delegate or the IAM team lead. If provisioning has not occurred within 1?hour of manager approval, escalate to the IAM Operations sub-team with the following details: ticket number, requester, target group, approval timestamp, and any error logs from Azure AD Connect or Group Management scripts. For repeated failures or suspected misconfiguration, involve the Security Operations group to review conditional access policies that might be blocking group membership escalation.

Keywords: access request, manager approval, security group, SharePoint access, file share permission, distribution list, Entra ID, Azure AD, self-service portal, IT Help Teams, provisioning timeline, access denied, approval workflow, IAM, Identity & Access Management